

8.5 Post Mission: Advances and Battle Scars

Advances

The Zone is a splendid teacher – if you live long enough to learn its lessons. Upgrading Gear and Equipment, improving Skill sets, transforming a green Rookie who barely knows the noisy end of an AK into reliable Hardened soldier, or even a Veteran Zone hunter, takes patience, skill, and luck. Campaign Advances are a measurable way

to track your fighters' progress, improve their abilities, and even acquire new skills. There's a bit of bookkeeping involved but treat it like kill marks carved in the stock of your rifle and it'll be easier.

Crew Credit

First thing to understand is all Advances are credited to your entire Crew, not the individual. Achievements like surviving missions, killing Zone Hostiles and/or opponents, salvaging Hot Spots, accomplishing the Mission Objective, go into a Crew pool. This might seem unfair at first, but once you're accepted in a Crew, everything is an even split. Of course, you can improve a particular character that's doing well, but this allows

the Crew Leader to use Advances to improve any member according to the greater needs of the unit.

So, the next question is: what do I get credit for? And the one after that usually is: what gives me the most credit?

Campaign Advances are given for accomplishing any of the four following tasks. Surviving, Killing, Salvaging Hot Spots, Achieving the Objective. You get one Advance for Surviving a Zone Run, one for each Zone Hostile and/or rival Crew kill. Three Advances for each Hot Spot you clear, and Five for accomplishing the Mission's main goal.

Put Out of Action and didn't recover before the mission ended? Well that rattled your cage. Your comrades dragged you out and you escaped with your life. No Advance for you. Roll on the Battle Scars table and thank Saint Strelok you made it out at all.

1. Surviving the Mission. Any disaster you can walk away from is a good one, eh? It's true. Stunned? It happens. Hit and Wounded but revived during the mission? Keep your head down next time. Squads get One Advance for every squad member that survives and is not Out of Action at the end of the mission.
2. Killing Enemies. Be it Zone Hostiles or a rival crew member. You get One Advance for every unit you kill or put Out of Action. Multiple model units count as a single unit, so you've got to take down the entire swarm/mob to get credit.
3. Salvage a Hot Spot. On top of the Kill credit and Salvage, a Crew gets Three Advances for every Hot Spot successfully looted.
4. Accomplish the Mission Objective. You did the job you went there to do. Well done. Five Advances for your crew, plus whatever Salvage.

Advance Pool and Spending Advances

It's important to remember Advances racked up by Crew members are not credited to the individual character model but rather go into the Crew's Advance Pool. These Advances are traded in (or spent) however the Crew Boss sees fit, regardless of a particular model's actual contribution. *The ghosts of communism die hard, eh comrade?* Think of it as an investment to your collective security. Unspent Advances remain in the crew's Advance Pool.

Model Stat Line

For every 10 Advances, a Crew Leader can improve one of his crew's (or their own) Model Stat line by One. The hard lessons taught by the Zone have filtered down to their bones: they fight harder or use their armor and cover that much better. Maybe they move a hair quicker or are no longer easily unnerved by the Zone's horrors. Whichever it is, the Player Model's Combat Ability, Armor Rating, Movement, or Will are improved by 1 (1"/Action in the case of Movement).

Additional Equipment Slot

For every 10 Advances, a Crew member can add an additional Equipment Slot to their Model Stat line. Perhaps the Bone Doc learned how to distribute their gear load more efficiently in order to carry more Med-Kits. Maybe one of your shooters wanted to trick out their AK-74 to be ready for any situation. Could be that Scrounger taught themselves how to be really handy with a Detector *and* the Binoculars. It's your call.

New Skills

For every 15 Advances you can add a single new Skill to one of your crew members. Let's say you want to give your Bone Doc the Hustle ability to help them get to the wounded faster. Steady Hands would certainly be a benefit to that crew member lugging around that SVD sniper rifle. Whatever you choose, it has to be consistent with the model's existing designation and equipment. For example, no giving the Unload Skill to someone with an RPG.

Note the Skill and Gear limitations for the three different Combat Experience levels apply only to NEWLY RECRUITED members. Advances allow you to improve on the initial restrictions.

Promotions

Live long enough, you're bound to learn something. This is particularly true in the Zone. For every Five Missions a Player Model survives, (i.e. not Out of Action at the end of the Zone Run) they are promoted to the next Experience level and their model Stat line is adjusted accordingly. So a Rookie moves to Hardened and a Hardened moves to Veteran. Model Stat adjustments are automatically applied on promotion. Adjust the Model's Stat Line accordingly. If a Model's Stat Line has previously been improved by Advances, the Promotion benefits do not apply in that particular area. Promotions do **not** apply to Veterans. Their Stat Line is improved by Advances only.

Messy Resolutions

All the shouting, smoke, gunfire, explosions, bullets flying around, mutants jumping out from everywhere, it was kind of hard to see who did what and when. Who gets the credit when more than one crew accomplishes a task? Your guys cleared the Hostiles from a Hot Spot, but then some other *chuvak* jumped in and grabbed the loot.

Well, you get the Kill Credits and they get the Hot Spot Salvage credit. You want 'fair'? Look between 'failure' and 'fraud' in the dictionary. Bet you'll plan better next time, eh?

Professional Development

Advances can also be purchased. Let's say you trade in a good haul of loot and maybe even an Artifact. Crews can purchase Advances at the Stalls at the rate of 1,500 Zone Script (ZS) per 1 Advance. We'll assume you're paying for some expert instruction or training at one of the larger, established camps inside the Zone rather than blowing it all on vodka and strippers. Like all Advances, purchased ones are added to the crew Pool and can be spent as the Boss sees fit.

Battle Scars

The Med-Kits in *Zona Alfa* essentially grant models the ability to take hits and survive (see page 22). Think of them as extra Wounds. As explained earlier, if a model is Wounded and has no Med-Kit of their own to off-set the damage, they are considered Out of Action and are out of play until they are revived by someone with a Med-Kit. If they are revived **before the end of the game**, they can get up and return to the fight.

However, any time a player character is Out of Action and not revived before the mission ends, they have one of those 'Near Death' experiences than profoundly

affects their character. Near-death survivors are said to have 'Battle Scars' and suffer from some kind of permanent effect or quirk.

For every model in your crew that was put Out of Action and remained incapacitated for the duration of the game, roll a D6 on Battle Scars Table. Note the result and make a notation on the crew member's roster. Over time, it's entirely possible crew members could suffer from the effects of multiple 'Battle Scars'. Word of advice: any more than two, you might want to consider retiring them and hiring a new Crew member.

Battle Scars Table	
D6 Roll	Battle Scar
1	Obsessed: Battle Lust. Wants to kill every enemy/hostile they see. Model must roll and pass a Will check at the start of each Activation to act as normal (Will check is a Free Action). Otherwise, they must attempt to kill every enemy in LOS or move to contact if no enemies are visible
2	Obsessed: Must Salvage. Has to search every Hot Spot. Model must roll and pass a Will Check at the start of each Activation to act as normal (Will check is a Free Action). If failed, they must move toward nearest Hot Spot, regardless of the Boss' orders.
3	Slow: -1" to Movement. No jumping or climbing without ladder or stairs.
4	Squeamish: Will check to enter Melee and when charged by Hostile (Will check is a Free Action). -1 CA/Melee. Failure means the Model must spend 1 Action to move away from Melee threat.
5	Dazed and Confused: -1 to all Will checks.
6	It's just a flesh wound. No Effect.

Obsessed Models want to ignore orders and act on their obsession (try to kill every enemy in sight or try to search every Hot Spot). Each time an Obsessed model is Activated, they must pass a Will check on 1D10 to act normally. This Will check is a free Action, but if the Will check is failed, they must immediately move, Attack, or Attempt to Trigger and Search the nearest visible Hot Spot. If a Battle-Scarred model manages to receive both the Must Kill and Must Salvage results, whichever object is nearest takes precedence.

8.6 Post Mission: The Stalls

Need a new bolt cover for your AK? Go to The Stalls. A new gas mask? A replacement crew member? The Stalls. Anything and everything a Zone hunter and a Crew Leader needs to do their job can be found there.

The Stalls is a roving, open air exchange. They are never in the same spot two days in a row, constantly on the move, advertized only via the Zone grapevine, but somehow everyone who needs to know about it, finds out where it will be when they need it. Think of it as a farmer's market. Without the farmers. And with lots of guns. This is where your crew will reequip between missions, converting valuable Salvage into new gear, ammo resupply, improved body armor, and replacement crew members.

The only legal tender accepted at the Stalls is Zone Script (ZS), so you'll need to visit the Traders to have your loot converted into hard currency (of course they take a cut). The Zone's economy is set at the 'AK Standard': the fixed exchange rate for a working AK-47, and all Zone Script bills are printed, circulated, and accounted for by the Trader faction. Which could be the reason the Bandits target them so often!

When trading at The Stalls, first you have to convert your Salvage into Zone Script. Equipment, Artifacts, and Salvage sell for listed price, less the Traders' 10% cut. So that 2,000 Value worth of Salvage you pulled in that last run will net you 1,800 in Zone Script. From there, you can wander the booths picking up new Gear, or stop by the bar and hire a recruit. Don't forget to set some aside for retirement. Prices for new Equipment are listed in the table below.

Equipment Price Table	
Item	Price (Zone Script)
Binoculars	220
1 Dose of Electric Juice	110
Gas Mask	220
1 Med-Kit	275
Red Dot Sight	440
Detector	550
Tool Kit	660
NODs	825
1 load of Hot Load Ammo	385
Scope	825
Chest Rig	1,100
Load Bearing Vest	1,650
Under Barrel Grenade Launcher	1,980
Kevlar Plates	1,980
Heavy Weapon Reload	2,200

Armor

Tired of running around in patchwork body armor or old surplus with conspicuous holes in important places? The cost to upgrade your personal protection is simple: 1,000 Zone Script per level of Armor Rating. So that Military Body Armor will run you 6,000 ZS. The good news is you can trade in your current armor at 50% of cost. Not great, but getting 1,500 for your worn, Improvised Armor vest will take some of the edge off.

Weapons and Explosives

So that Shotgun just doesn't have the reach you need? And melee with a sniper rifle is like flailing around with a boat oar – plus it knocks your scope out of zero? Well the Stalls make a Texas gun show look like a Sunday knitting circle. Plunk down your Zone Script and get what you need. No waiting period or background checks here. Oh, and you can get 50% of the retail on your current weapon if you want to sell it!

Weapon Price Table	
Weapon	Price (Zone Script)
Combat Knife	100
Machete, Axe	150
Chainsaw	250
Pistol	200
Magnum Pistol	300
Shotgun	350
Flame Thrower or Chemical Sprayer *	400
SMG	400
Assault Rifle (AK 74)	500
Battle Rifle (AK-15)	650
Grenade Launcher * (M79 or Milkor MGL)	1,000
Squad LMG (RPD or RPK)	2,000
Rocket Launcher (RPG) *	2,000
HMG (crew-served. 2 minimum. stationary)	4,000
Mortar * (crew-served. 2 minimum. stationary)	4,000
Sniper Rifle (Dragunov SVD-63 or VSSK Vychlop)	4,000

*Weapons come with 5 Rounds to start. Additional ammunition must be purchased separately (see page 32).

Hand Grenades and Explosives: a new twist on the phrase ‘Disposable Item’. You’ll want to re-up on these between every mission.

Remember, Grenades come in pairs, you can mix and match to taste, and the first set does **not** take up an Equipment Slot. Additional sets do, however.

Grenade and Explosives Price Table	
Weapon	Price (Zone Script, Per Item)
Molotov Cocktail	150
Flash Bang	300
Smoke Grenade	300
Hand Grenade	300
Satchel Charge	500

Recruits

New Blood, Warm Bodies, Fresh Meat, Zone Fodder... deadly as the Exclusion Zone is, there’s always someone hanging around the Bar looking to sign on with a crew. Prospects range from punks fresh out of prison with no other career options, to recently de-mobilized military vets addicted to the rush of combat and the camaraderie of shared hardship. All new hires come with the Stats, Armor, Weapons, and Gear listed in their respective profile. See below for Hire Price and details.

Rookie (Hire Price: 1,500 ZS)

Name	Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
Dmitry Dukh	5"	4	Improvised Body Armor (3) Counts as Obscured Target when in Cover.	4
Options				
Choose 1 Ranged Weapon, 1 Melee Weapon. 2 Grenades, and 2 Pieces of Basic Equipment.				

Hardened (Hire Price: 2,500 ZS)

Name	Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
Kirill Kirza	6"	5	Civilian Body Armor (5) Counts as Obscured Target when in Cover.	5
Options				
Choose 1 Ranged Weapon, 1 Melee Weapon. 2 Grenades, 1 Skill, and 2 Pieces of Basic Equipment.				

Veteran (Hire Price: 4,000 ZS)

Name	Movement	Combat Ability	Armor	Will
Timur Tyazheliy	6"	6	Civilian Body Armor (5) Counts as Obscured Target when in Cover.	6
Options				
Choose 1 Ranged Weapon, 1 Melee Weapon. 2 Grenades, 2 Skills, and 3 Pieces of Basic Equipment.				

And there you have one-stop shopping for the four essential ingredients of any successful Zone venture: weapons, ammo, armor, and warm bodies.